

**Relocating the Fantasy: A Queer Theoretical Analysis
of Tyler, The Creator's Evolution in Hip Hop**

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INTRODUCTION

hip-hop has historically been a site of rigid gender performances and heteronormativity. During the rise of hip-hop, black male artists perpetuated a stereotypical masculinity—aggressive, strong, straight. This is a case study on gender theory in hip-hop music. This essay examines the evolution of gender expression and sexual identity within the hip-hop genre, specifically focusing on the career trajectory of Tyler, The Creator, an artist who has successfully transitioned from using homophobic language to being an icon of queer expression. The theory of Queer Theory & Gender Performativity from Judith Butler is used to analyze how Tyler "performs" different versions of masculinity and how these performances are constructed through costume, alter-egos, and lyrics. And the "Male Gaze" theory from Laura Mulvey is applied to examine how Tyler's music videos shift the "Male Gaze" away from the objectification of women and toward a "Queer Gaze" that centers male-to-male desire and emotional vulnerability.

Through my research for my literature review, I noticed that many scholars focused on black masculinity in gangsta rap and hip-hop, but only a few discussed black masculinity in contemporary hip-hop music. Therefore, this analysis focus on masculinity in hip-hop music, specifically with the case study of Tyler, The Creator. This essay addresses how Tyler, The Creator subverted the stereotype of men in the hip-hop genre.

LITERATURE REVIEW

Scholars often describe hip-hop as a space where a specific, rigid type of masculinity is performed. Previous research from Tricia Rose (1994) argues that hip-hop is a ground where

black male identity is constructed against a backdrop of systemic pressure, and this often results in a "hard" or hyper-masculine performance. While this masculinity not only exists in male artists but also in female artists, Tricia Rose argues that "Rap's sexual politics are not just a reflection of sexism in the larger society; they are a response to it, a way of negotiating the pressures of racial and gendered identity in a world that often denies both." (Rose 1994, p.147).

This aligns well with Queer Theory. If the "dominant society" of hip-hop is heteronormative, an artist's transition into queer expression can be viewed as bringing a "hidden transcript" into the public eye. As Judith Butler (1990) claimed "Gender is the repeated stylization of the body, a set of repeated acts within a highly rigid regulatory frame that congeal over time to produce the appearance of substance, of a natural sort of being." (Butler, 1990, p.33). This kind of transition can be widely seen in artists who try to navigate or break those rules in the hip-hop music industry. Therefore, masculine or feminine identities are constructed through continuous social performances. And if traditional hip-hop masculinity is a constructed act, it leads to another possibility that queer artists may intentionally 'trouble' this performance by adopting alternate aesthetics and subverting expected behaviors.

While Laura Mulvey(1975) suggests that "In a world ordered by sexual imbalance, pleasure in looking has been split between active male and passive female." (Mulvey, 1975, p.837) bell hooks (1992) argues that "There is power in looking"(hooks, 1992, p.115). She suggests that the dominant white, patriarchal narrative can be disrupted by Black subjects if they wisely choose how they are represented. By synthesizing Mulvey's definition of the gaze with Judith Butler's concept of "performativity", this essay will investigate how Tyler, The Creator utilizes the

camera to dismantle heteronormative visual hierarchies and establish a queer, oppositional gaze within hip-hop.

ANALYSIS

Tyler, The Creator transformed his visual and lyrical identity from aggressive, dark masculinity to colorful and soulful queer expression. From 2009 to 2015, Tyler, The Creator was considered the leader of the collective Odd Future for his "horrorcore" rap. His debut albums, *Bastard* and *Goblin*, were criticized for violent imagery and frequent use of homophobic slurs. Many of his lyrics portray masculinity by showing dark side and acting cool. In his music video for "Yonkers", the screen is in black and white. When he appeared, he had the word 'kill' written on his hand. His music video ends with a suicide; it features repulsive insects, gold chains, a noose, and blood from the nose. The whole music video is surrounded by a horrible and dark atmosphere, which was very commonly used in that time in the hip-hop industry. By this dark visual language, he tended to leave audiences an impression of a strong and powerful man that fits the audiences' projection and the inherent structure of heteronormative hegemony.

"While Tyler, The Creator has been accused of homophobia and misogyny, his decision to acknowledge his same-sex desire through his music challenges the stereotypical constructions of black masculinity that have historically been a feature of hip-hop culture."(Blanchon. 2020, p.52)

From 2017, Tyler's aesthetic shifted with the album "Flower Boy". He began including lyrics that alluded to his own queer identity. He explicitly raps: "I've been kissing white boys since 2004." In his song "I Ain't Got Time!" By wearing a blonde bob wig and pastel suits in the *IGOR* era, he is actively performing a "softer," non-binary aesthetic that rejects the "thug" or "macho"

stereotypes of traditional rap. Instead of using women body as props to showcase his heteronormative status and power, Tyler centered his own body, essentially creating a "Queer Gaze" where the viewer is forced to look at male-to-male desire, breaking the traditional "heteronormative gaze" of the music industry. By maximizing this "Queer Gaze", not only is the rapper deconstructing heteronormative visual hierarchies, but also audiences are invited to participate in this new vision.

From Tyler's conversion in the hip-hop industry, we see his early hyper-violent masculinity was a "performance" demanded by the hip-hop genre. In the hip-hop industry, there is often a huge gap between the public image that many artists project and their private lives. This phenomenon interprets that the aggressive, heteronormative gender repetitiveness is merely a required performance rather than an authentic identity. "Relocate my fantasy, I stay in reality." Tyler wrote to look back at a genre that tried to exclude his identity, creating a site of visual resistance. Tyler tried to get out of the binary passive-and-active perspective by creating a new gaze from which a colorful queer man actively behaved and looked out at the viewer in the video.

CONCLUSIONS

In conclusion, Tyler, The Creator's artistic footprint represents a significant conversion from the rigid, heteronormative constraints of traditional hip-hop. By applying Judith Butler's theory of gender performativity, this essay has demonstrated how Tyler's evolving personas reveal the "macho" rapper identity as a constructed performance rather than a born truth. Furthermore, through an analysis of the gaze in his music videos, it is evident that Tyler subverts the patriarchal male gaze into an oppositional, queer gaze that centers vulnerability and male-to-

male desire. Ultimately, Tyler's work serves as a critical intervention in pop media, suggesting that the boundaries of gender and authenticity in music are increasingly fluid. His career is in a more inclusive future where the performance of Black masculinity is no longer restricted by monolithic genre expectations.

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